

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 24

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A young chess player at a national tournament faces a famously aggressive opponent on board one, and must decide whether to trust a calculation she can barely believe.

1

The playing hall was the loudest silent room I had ever sat in. Three hundred wooden clocks, each one ticking out of step with the next, produced a sound like rain on glass that never quite became weather. Somewhere two boards down, a player coughed once and was glared at by half the room. I straightened my pieces for the fourth time. Across the table, my opponent had not yet sat down. He was famous for arriving last, and famous for what he did when he did.

2

His name was Damian Voss. He was seventeen, two years older than I was, and he played, my coach had warned me, “like someone setting a small, polite fire to your house.” On the screen above the stage, the live board for table one displayed our names in capital letters, and beneath them, the empty squares of the starting position. I felt the eyes of the hall on those squares, and, by extension, on me. I put my hands in my lap so that no one would see them shake.

3

He arrived three minutes before the clock would have started without him. He nodded — not unkindly — pressed his clock to start mine, and sat back. I pushed my king’s pawn forward. The game began. For the first ten moves I played the variation I had prepared at four o’clock that morning, my hand moving each piece as though it belonged to someone else. He answered each move almost instantly, which was either a sign that he had prepared the same line, or a sign that he wanted me to think so.

4

By move sixteen the position had become what my coach called “untidy” — pieces tangled in the centre, both kings still uncastled, threats running in three directions. I had a knight on the rim of the board where, the textbooks insisted, knights did not belong. He had, somewhere in the chaos, the kind of

attacking formation that turned annotated games into short ones. I looked at the position, and I looked at it again, and on the third look, I saw it. A sacrifice. Knight takes pawn on f7. If he took with the king, my queen came to h5, his rook fell, his king went for a long, fatal walk. If he did not take, the knight returned, and I had won a pawn for free.

5

I counted the moves. I counted them again. Three moves deep, then four, then five. I could see the win. And then, in that very particular way that only chess can do, I could not. The pieces blurred. A doubt the size of a small stone settled in my chest. What if his king did not go to that square? What if he simply played another move I had not considered, one of those quiet, ugly moves that strong players see and I, fifteen years old and on board one for the first time, did not? I sat back. I drank water that tasted of nothing. The clock ticked, indifferent.

6

I have read since that the loneliness of a chess player at the board is a particular kind of loneliness. It is not the loneliness of being unwanted, which is loud; it is the loneliness of being unhelpable, which is quiet. Two hundred people in the hall could see my position. Three of them, perhaps, could see what I had seen. Not one of them could tell me whether I was right. I looked, just once, at the back of the hall, where my coach sat with his arms folded and his face arranged into the careful nothing of someone who has been told, by the rules, not to help. He met my eye. He did not nod. He did not need to.

7

I returned to the board. I reached for the knight. My hand was steadier than I expected it to be, which surprised me more than the move itself. I took the pawn. I pressed the clock. Across the table, Damian Voss leaned forward for the first time in the game. He looked at the knight as though it had said something rude to him. Then, very slowly, he began to think, and as he thought, I understood, with a cold, clean sort of clarity, that I had not been wrong. The win or the loss did not yet matter. The calculation had been mine, and I had trusted it.

8

He played for forty more minutes before he shook my hand. I do not remember the walk back to my seat, only that the hall, which had felt enormous, had become an ordinary room with chairs in it. My coach said nothing, which was, from him, an extravagant compliment. That night, in the hotel, I lay awake and listened to the air conditioner and thought, not about the game, but about the moment my hand had reached for the knight, and how quiet, in the end, the bravest decision of my life had sounded.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator describes the playing hall as “the loudest silent room I had ever sat in.” Explain, in your own words, what is **unusual** about this description and what it suggests about the atmosphere. [2]

2. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 1 that suggests the players in the hall were under strict discipline. [1]

From Paragraph 2

3. The coach says Damian Voss plays “like someone setting a small, polite fire to your house.” Explain what this comparison suggests about his style of play. [2]

4. Why does the narrator put her hands in her lap? Answer in your own words. [1]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says her hand moved each piece “as though it belonged to someone else.” What does this tell us about her state of mind at the start of the game? [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. In Paragraph 4, the narrator describes seeing a sacrifice. Give **two** details from this paragraph that show the position on the board was complicated and dangerous. [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says, “A doubt the size of a small stone settled in my chest.” Explain what is **effective** about this description. [2]

8. The clock is described as “indifferent.” What does this word suggest about the narrator’s feelings at this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator distinguishes between “the loneliness of being unwanted” and “the loneliness of being unhelpable.” Explain, in your own words, what she means by the second kind of loneliness. [2]

10. The coach’s face is described as being “arranged into the careful nothing of someone who has been told, by the rules, not to help.” Explain what the phrase **the careful nothing** suggests about the coach. [2]

From Paragraph 7

11. The narrator says she understood “with a cold, clean sort of clarity.”

- (a) What does this tell us about how she felt after making her move? [1]
- (b) Identify the **literary device** used in the phrase “cold, clean sort of clarity” and explain its effect. [2]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the booming market for second-hand luxury goods, and what it reveals about modern attitudes to ownership.

1

A decade ago, the phrase “pre-owned handbag” carried, for most luxury buyers, a faint odour of compromise. Today, it sits comfortably on the homepage of some of the most fashionable apps in the world. The market for second-hand luxury goods — handbags, watches, jewellery, designer clothing — has, by the most cautious estimates, tripled in size since 2017. The consultancy Bain reported in 2023 that resale was growing roughly four times as quickly as the primary luxury market itself, and that, by the end of the decade, almost one in every five luxury items sold worldwide is expected to have been worn by someone else first.

2

The platforms driving this shift are familiar to anyone under thirty. Vestiaire Collective, The RealReal, Vinted’s higher-end cousins, and a constellation of smaller specialists have made it as easy to list a five-year-old coat as it once was to list a paperback. Photographs are taken on a phone; authentication is handled, for a fee, by the platform; payment arrives in a matter of days. What had been, in the era of the second-hand shop, a slow and slightly furtive transaction has become, in the era of the app, a public and rather glamorous one.

3

The appeal to younger buyers is not difficult to read, though it is more layered than older commentators sometimes assume. Value matters, of course: a desirable bag bought second-hand can cost forty per cent less than the same bag new, and certain models, paradoxically, hold or even gain value over time. Sustainability matters too: a generation that has grown up with climate anxiety is sceptical of buying anything that will be discarded within a season, and a second-hand purchase carries a smaller environmental footprint than a new one. And exclusivity, awkward as it is to admit, matters most of all: a discontinued model, a colour no longer produced, a sold-out collaboration — these become, on a resale platform, the only way in.

4

The luxury houses themselves have responded to this revolution in two ways, which look contradictory but in fact are not. Publicly, several have launched their own resale channels, certifying the authenticity of pre-owned items and, in some cases, repurchasing them outright; one Swiss watchmaker now sells what it calls “Certified Pre-Owned” pieces from its own boutiques, with a fresh warranty included. Privately, the same houses continue to fight, in courtrooms and customs offices, against the broader resale trade, on the grounds that it strips them of control over how their products are presented, priced, and ultimately understood.

5

The question of authenticity sits, uncomfortably, at the centre of the boom. The counterfeit industry has not stood still while resale has grown; on the contrary, it has grown alongside it, in increasingly sophisticated forms. The “superfake” — a counterfeit so well made that even trained eyes struggle to distinguish it from the genuine article — has become the resale platforms’ single greatest operational threat. Most major platforms now employ in-house authenticators, some assisted by artificial-intelligence tools trained on millions of images of stitching, hardware, and serial numbers. Mistakes, however, do happen, and a wrongly authenticated bag, once sold, can pass through several owners before anyone catches it.

6

What the resale boom seems also to be quietly rewriting is the older idea of ownership itself. To buy

something new and use it until it falls apart was, for much of the twentieth century, a small badge of seriousness, a sign that one had chosen well. To buy something pre-owned, wear it for a season, list it again, and recoup most of one's outlay is a different relationship altogether: closer to renting, but rented from no one, and with the option, at any moment, of holding on. Younger buyers do not seem to find this strange. They speak of their wardrobes as portfolios, of bags as assets, of items being “rotated” rather than “kept” — a vocabulary that would have baffled their grandparents and that, increasingly, appears in the spreadsheets of investment analysts as well.

7

Whether this represents a healthier relationship with luxury — less wasteful, more thoughtful, more honest about value — or a colder one, in which even an heirloom is held with one eye on the exit, is a question on which serious people disagree. What is no longer in dispute is the scale. The second-hand luxury market is not a curiosity at the edge of the industry. It is, very quickly, becoming the industry; and the houses that built their reputations on the idea that their products would last forever are being asked, in a way they had not quite expected, to mean it.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says the phrase “pre-owned handbag” once carried “a faint odour of compromise.” Explain, in your own words, what this suggests about how second-hand luxury goods were once viewed. [2]

13. According to Paragraph 1, give **two** details that show how rapidly the second-hand luxury market is growing. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. The writer contrasts the “era of the second-hand shop” with “the era of the app.” Explain, in your own words, **two** ways in which the transaction has changed. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says exclusivity “matters most of all” to younger buyers. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 3 that supports this claim. [1]

16. The writer says certain models “paradoxically, hold or even gain value over time.” Why does the writer use the word **paradoxically**? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer describes the response of the luxury houses as looking “contradictory but in fact” not contradictory. Explain, in your own words, the two responses and why they are not truly in conflict. [2]

18. Why is the phrase **Certified Pre-Owned** placed in inverted commas? [1]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer calls authenticity an “uncomfortable” question at the centre of the boom. Give **two** reasons from Paragraph 5 why authenticity has become difficult to guarantee. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says younger buyers describe “their wardrobes as portfolios, of bags as assets, of items being ‘rotated’ rather than ‘kept’.” What is the **effect** of listing these expressions one after another? [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer says that luxury houses “are being asked, in a way they had not quite expected, to mean it.”

- (a) What is the writer’s **tone** in this final sentence? [1]
(b) Explain, in your own words, what the luxury houses are now being “asked to mean.” [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why second-hand luxury goods appeal to younger buyers**, and **the concerns and difficulties that the resale boom has created**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Younger buyers are drawn to second-hand luxury because ...

— END OF PAPER —